what perfectly with the album's title—one that alludes to everything from Zoroastrianism to *The Jungle Book*. "I was also thinking of being in school in Lahore, and seeing these vultures everywhere—on the sides of roads, or perched on big, old trees."

Aftab was just 18 when her cover of 'Hallelujah' went viral in Pakistan. "I had only sent it to a few friends on email, but then it reached a lot more people. It set me up with a lot of confidence, but it also helped me understand how the internet and trolls work." Alongside her two earlier albums—*Bird Under Water* (2014) and *Siren Islands* (2018)—Aftab's rendition of that Leonard Cohen classic can now be found on YouTube. 'Mehram', the song she recently recorded for Coke Studio, has also been viewed nearly 10 million times. "Coke Studio has become this rite of passage for Pakistani musicians, but if it had been a plastic disco, Bollywood-adjacent party, I would not attend," she smiles.

When recording and shooting for Coke Studio in Karachi, Aftab felt moved and inspired, but the Berklee College of Music graduate tells us that New York is now home: "I feel that here I have freedom to do things I want to do without the pressure of people judging me. I really love and respect my roots, but I also feel if you are a creative person with really big goals, you need to be in a city like New York."

Featuring a new collaboration with Anoushka Shankar, the deluxe edition of *Vulture Prince* will release on June 24. Aftab also hopes to release new music with Love in Exile, a trio she is part of with pianist-composer Vijay Iyer and bassist Shahzad Ismaily. Iyer had once told an interviewer, "[Aftab] makes something beautiful, but it's not only beauty for its own sake. It's actually beauty as a form of care." Iyer, Aftab feels, was being generous, but 'care', she says, matters to her: "Every time I compose a body of work, I want to push the envelope a little bit further. I want it to be a blueprint for something that doesn't exist. That's a huge undertaking which requires care." Aftab feels this approach to music does, in turn, offer listeners melodic solace. There's truth here. To listen to Aftab is to be looked after. ■

–Shreevatsa Nevatia

HOW THE WEST WAS WON

A brief history of how South Asian music went international

1955

When sarod maestro **Ali Akbar Khan** went to the US for the first time, he was struck by how westerners found it hard to believe that India had its own music. Released in 1955, the success of *Music of India* prompted HMV India to start producing LP-length Hindustani classical recordings.



1966

Marked by rapturous applause and rave reviews, **M.S. Subbulakshmi**'s UN concert in October 1966 was surely historic, but her travel history also proves that the 'first lady of Carnatic music' had by then already filled concert halls from Edinburgh to Boston.

1967

Released in 1967, *East Meets West* went on to win its two collaborators–violinist **Yehudi Menuhin** and sitarist **Ravi Shankar**–a Grammy Award. Not just was Shankar the first Asian musician to win a Grammy, his influence abroad began to spread fast.

1974

After his jazz fusion band **Mahavishnu Orchestra** dissolved, British guitarist John McLaughlin joined violinist L. Shankar, tabla virtuoso Zakir Hussain and ghatam master T.H. "Vikku" Vinayakram to form **Shakti**. The band's output was sporadic, but their sound felt iconic from the start.

1978

Ustad Vilayat Khan played in England in 1951, long before Ravi Shankar, but by the time he reached Boston for his first US tour in 1978, his rival had cornered the loyal sitar audiences. Yet, reviews hailed Khan as "the world's greatest sitar player".



1985

By 1997, the year he sadly passed away at the age of 48, the list of **Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan**'s fans included everyone from Eddie Vedder to Madonna, but it was in 1985, when Khan took the stage at the WOMAD festival in Essex, that he made music history. It was the moment when qawwali first went global.

1999

'Asian underground' once applied to everything–**Apache Indian**'s reggae and **Cornershop**'s 'Brimful of Asha' (1998). It was in 1999 that **Nitin Sawhney**'s *Beyond Skin* and **Talvin Singh**'s Mercury Prize-winning *OK* gave fledgling attempts at fusion a mainstream spin.

2009

The South Asian diaspora didn't need *Slumdog Millionaire*'s rousing soundtrack to discover **A.R. Rahman**–they were grooving to 'Chikku Bukku Rayile' and 'Chaiyya Chaiyya' long before. But in the end, it took A.R. an operatic and touch over-the-top 'Jai Ho' to get Oscar and Grammy attention.